

Replication Project

NGO Aid, Pushing Back or Backing Down?

Original authors: Right, L., Springman, J. and Wibbels, E. (2025)

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Applied Statistical Methods II



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Explaining the Original Study

Original Research Question & Argument

Do international donors "push back" (withdraw aid) or "back down" (maintain aid) when recipient countries pass restrictive NGO laws?

Donor response depends on:

- **DOR (Relationship Orientation):**

Does the donor prioritize democracy aid in that specific country?

- **DOD (Donor Orientation):**

Is the donor globally committed to democracy?

Data: Dyadic dataset (Donor-Recipient pairs) excluding the US and small aid flows (<\$2M).



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Original Study: Model 1

Model: Linear model

Reason: estimate the effect of NGO laws on aid flows

$$Y_{ij,t} = \beta_1 \text{postpassage}_{ij,t} + \alpha_{ij} + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{ij,t}$$

*Dependent variables are logged using a log y - 1 transformation to handle 0\$ aid

*postpassage is a dummy variable of whether the law was passed

*alpha: controls for donor recipient specific factors

*year fixed effects

Results:

The coefficients are statistically insignificant.
Hence, this means that on average,
the effect of NGO law has no impact on
the volume of aid a country receives.

Next step:

=> the author implemented an **Interaction model**

TABLE 1. All donor responses to NGO law passage

	Dependent variable:		
	Total aid	Democracy aid	Economic aid
	(1)	(2)	(3)
NGO LAW PASSAGE	0.057 (0.177)	- 0.127 (0.220)	0.055 (0.218)



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Original Study: Model 2

Donor relationship DOR

Donor orientation DOD

Model: Interactive model

Reason: test whether donors' past commitment to democracy promotion conditions the effect of NGO law passage on aid flow

Results:

- > When NGO laws are passed, reductions in Aid for specific donor types (DOD) happen, Specifically in democracy aid
- > Democracy-focused donors pull-back

	Donor relationship DOR			Donor orientation DOD		
	Total aid (1)	Democracy aid (2)	Economic aid (3)	Total aid (4)	Democracy aid (5)	Economic aid (6)
NGO LAW PASSAGE	0.076 (0.389)	- 0.129 (0.548)	0.004 (0.454)	0.317* (0.165)	0.307 (0.226)	0.220 (0.207)
DO RELATIONSHIP	0.041 (0.231)	1.890*** (0.330)	- 0.740*** (0.285)			
NGO LAW × DOR	- 0.404 (0.258)	- 1.050*** (0.274)	- 0.015 (0.282)			
DO DONOR				- 0.372** (0.158)	0.507** (0.198)	- 0.585*** (0.182)
NGO LAW × DOD				- 0.772*** (0.185)	- 1.485*** (0.225)	- 0.486** (0.241)
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Dyad FEs	×	×	×	✓	✓	✓
Donor FEs	✓	✓	✓	×	×	×
No. of Dyad FE	n/a	n/a	n/a	1,045	1045	1,045
No. of Donor FE	19	19	19	n/a	n/a	n/a
Observations	12,785	12,783	12,784	12,312	12,310	12,311
R ²	0.176	0.203	0.200	0.705	0.620	0.706
Adjusted R ²	0.174	0.201	0.198	0.678	0.584	0.678



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My contribution: Twist 1

Original study: NGO Law → Aid Volume

Twist: Predicting NGO Restrictions - Reverse Causality

Aid Volume → NGO Law

Shifting the focus from donor behavior to recipient behavior

Do governments pass laws *because* aid is already declining?

Method: GLM to calculate probabilities with a binary outcome (NGO law -> 0/1) & removed first year of data for every country. I used a logit model to predict the probability of an event occurring.

```
twist1_model <- glm(event_int ~ prev_aid + civil_war + cpj.ihs,  
  data = df_twist,  
  family = binomial(link = "logit"))
```

Result:

Civil war is the strongest predictor in the model, nearly doubling the log-odds of passing this law.

Table 3: Twist 1: Logistic Regression Predicting NGO Law Enactment

	Dependent variable: Probability of NGO Law
Total Aid (Lagged)	0.065*** (0.002)
Civil War	0.889*** (0.032)
Press Freedom (CPJ)	0.254*** (0.017)
Constant	-2.541*** (0.033)
Observations	42,312
Log Likelihood	-19,004.880
Akaike Inf. Crit.	38,017.770

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01



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My contribution: Twist 2

Original Study: studies the fluctuation in amount in USD

Twist: analyzing binary choice of whether a donor gives anything at all instead of reductions

Method: GLM to calculate the Odds Ratio to see how much exactly less likely a country is to receive any aid after passing a restrictive law. This will provide clear punishment metric that a linear regression

```
twist2_model <- glm(gave_aid ~ dir.sig.event.l + DOD + civil_war,  
  data = df_twist2,  
  family = binomial(link = "logit"))
```

Result: The results show that for countries passing a restrictive NGO law, the odds of receiving aid are 2.47 times higher compared to those that do not.

Table 4: Twist 2: Odds Ratio of Receiving Any Aid After NGO Law

<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
Probability of Receiving Aid	
NGO Law (Lagged)	2.471*** (0.043)
Donor Democracy (DOD)	0.425*** (0.029)
Civil War	8.095*** (0.065)
Constant	2.902*** (0.017)
Observations	33,611
Log Likelihood	-16,678.120
Akaike Inf. Crit.	33,364.250

Contradicting results



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Key takeaways

Twist 1: NGO laws are primarily triggered by factors like Civil War rather than international aid signals.

Twist 2: While donors might reduce the volume of their aid as the original study suggests post law enforcement, they rarely choose to exit the relationship entirely especially in conflict zones.

Conclusion: Donors trim budgets to signal disapproval but stay present to address crises or maintain influence.



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Bibliography

Right, L., Springman, J. and Wibbels, E. (2025) 'Pushing Back or Backing Down? Evidence on Donor Responses to Restrictive NGO Legislation', *International Organization*, 79(4), pp. 759–786. doi:10.1017/S0020818325100957.

Link for replication files: <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=doi:10.7910/DVN/FIINC8>

Link for the study:

<https://www.cambridge.org/core/services/aop-cambridge-core/content/view/9365B7A1D39A5548351ADEC6E4F09181/S0020818325100957a.pdf/pushing-back-or-backing-down-evidence-on-donor-responses-to-restrictive-ngo-legislation.pdf#page=13.18>



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